A STAGE SET FOR SARMA

THE HUGELY POPULAR CHIEF MINISTER HAS COVERED ALL BASES: A GREAT RECORD IN INFRASTRUCTURE AND JOBS, LAYERS OF WELFARE SCHEMES AND POLARISATION OF VOTERS THROUGH THE 'MIYA' SCARE

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PTI

For more than 15 years, Himanta Biswa Sarma has been the most reliable electoral engine in Assam, winning assembly seats, Lok Sabha contests and even Rajya Sabha numbers when arithmetic alone fell short. He delivered for the Congress. He delivered for the BJP after switching in 2015. But April 9, 2026, is different. For the first time, Sarma enters an Assam election not as kingmaker but as king—the sitting chief minister. "This is his election," says one of his close confidants. "He is the product he is selling this time, not another chief ministerial face. So, the return must be higher."

For Sarma, winning is not enough; he wants to win bigger. The BJP first came to power in Assam in 2016 with 60 seats in the 126-member assembly, four short of the halfway mark of 64. Backed by allies, the NDA's combined tally stood at 86, and Sarbananda Sonowal became chief minister. In 2021, the BJP held its 60 seats and lifted its vote share from 29 to 33 per cent. The NDA's overall count, however, shrank by 11 seats, partly because ally Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) slid from 14 seats to nine.

This time, Sarma seeks to prove that he has been the best chief minister Assam never had, until now. He wants the NDA's collective tally to surge past 90, with the BJP alone clearing 70—that would approach, though fall short of, the 78 seats the Congress won in 2011, the highest by any single party this century, and a victory Sarma himself was the prime architect of. April 9 will also be a referendum on his model of governance: unapologetic Hindu assertion, positioning himself as the architect of socio-economic growth through infrastructure and industrial investment and the careful cultivation of a massive beneficiary vote bank.

The challenge is formidable in a state where Muslims constitute, unofficially, over 40 per cent of the population—34 per cent according to the 2011 Census—and have historically backed the Congress or the All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF). That challenge is compounded by Sarma's own provocations: his campaign has been built on explicit utterances against 'Miyas', a term often used as a slur for Muslims of Bangladeshi-immigrant origin, declaring that he doesn't need their votes, urging indigenous communities to "harass" them, and promising to "break their backbone" in his next tenure after having "broken their hands and legs" in this one.

Rewriting Geography

His strategy to expand the BJP's footprint began in 2023, when Assam's assembly constituencies were redrawn, with a heavy impact on Muslim-dominated areas. Where Muslim voters once had influence over 35 seats, delimitation has compressed them to 22. These con-